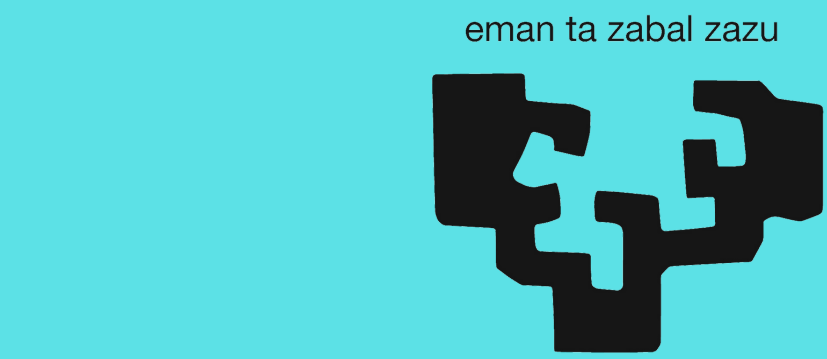




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Eye-tracking the Experienter Thematic Role

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Introduction

**Thematic
roles
approach [3]**



Experienter is a thematic role designates the participant of an event that experiences the mental state denoted by the verb [1]. It is a discrete linguistic category.

**Proto-Roles
approach [2]**



Experienter role fits into **Proto-Agent** category due to **sentience** entailment; it is less prototypical than Agent because Experienter only possesses one entailment.

Psycholinguistic evidence shows that Agents have different processing correlates than Themes [6]. Experienter processing has not been investigated yet.

Has the Experienter thematic role a specific processing pattern?

In order to determine this, we investigated argument structures with Experienter role [4, 5]:

Psych verbs

Perceptual verbs

Experienter-Theme
e.g. *love*

Experienter-Theme
e.g. *observe*

Agent-Experienter
e.g. *frighten*

Methods

Eye-tracking

48 Spanish native speakers (M=21 years).

Reading task

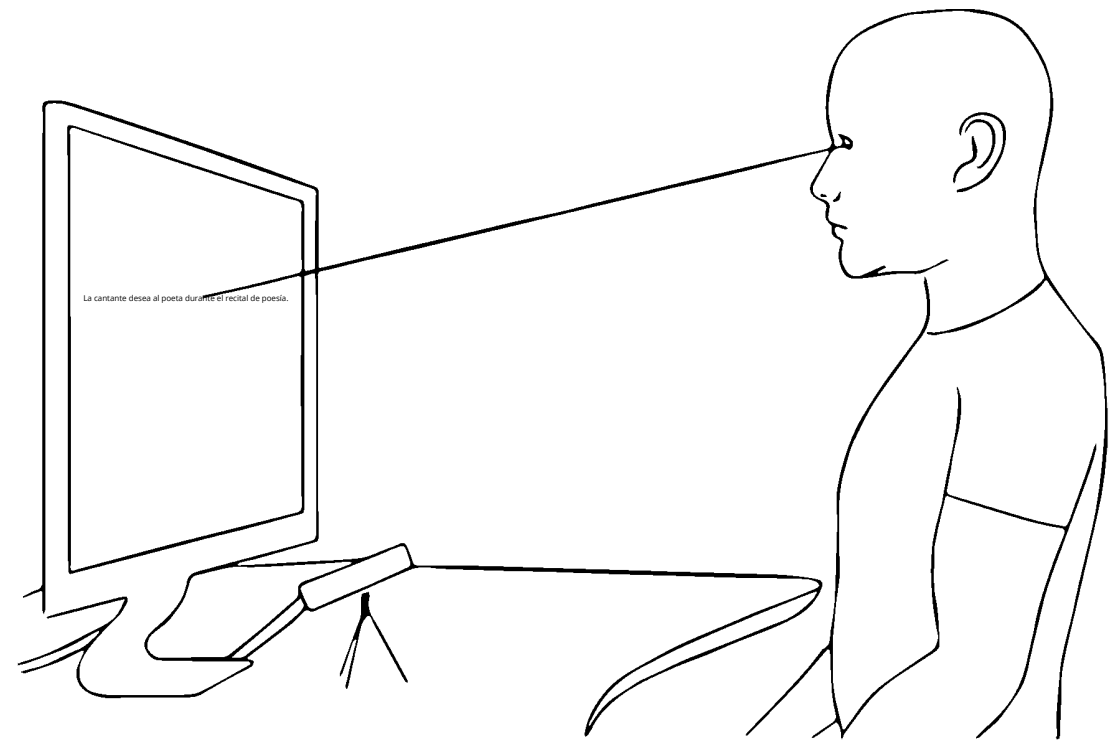
20 verbs per condition controlled by length and frequency.

40 experimental items and 80 fillers.

2x2 repeated measures design:

Verb Type (Psych vs. Non-psych)

Argument Structure (Experienter-Theme vs. Agent-Theme/Experienter)



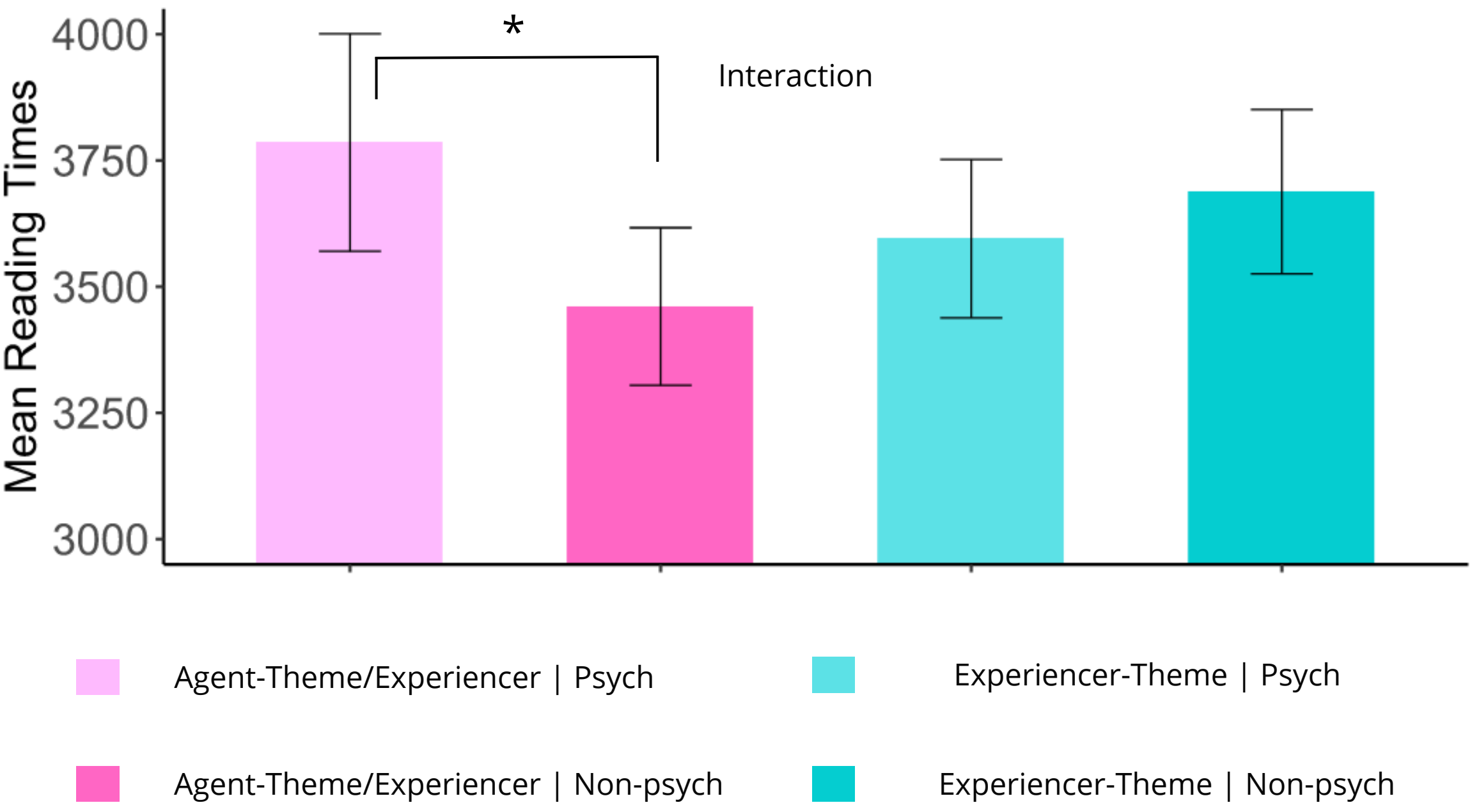
Materials

Verb Type	Argument Structure	Subject Region	Verb Region	Object Region	Post-object Region	Last-word Region
Psych	Experienter-Theme	La cantante	desea	al poeta	durante el recital de	poesía.
Psych	Agent-Experienter	La cantante	enamora	al poeta	durante el recital de	poesía.
Non-psych	Experienter-Theme	La cantante	contempla	al poeta	durante el recital de	poesía.
Non-psych	Agent-Theme	La cantante	abandona	al poeta	durante el recital de	poesía.

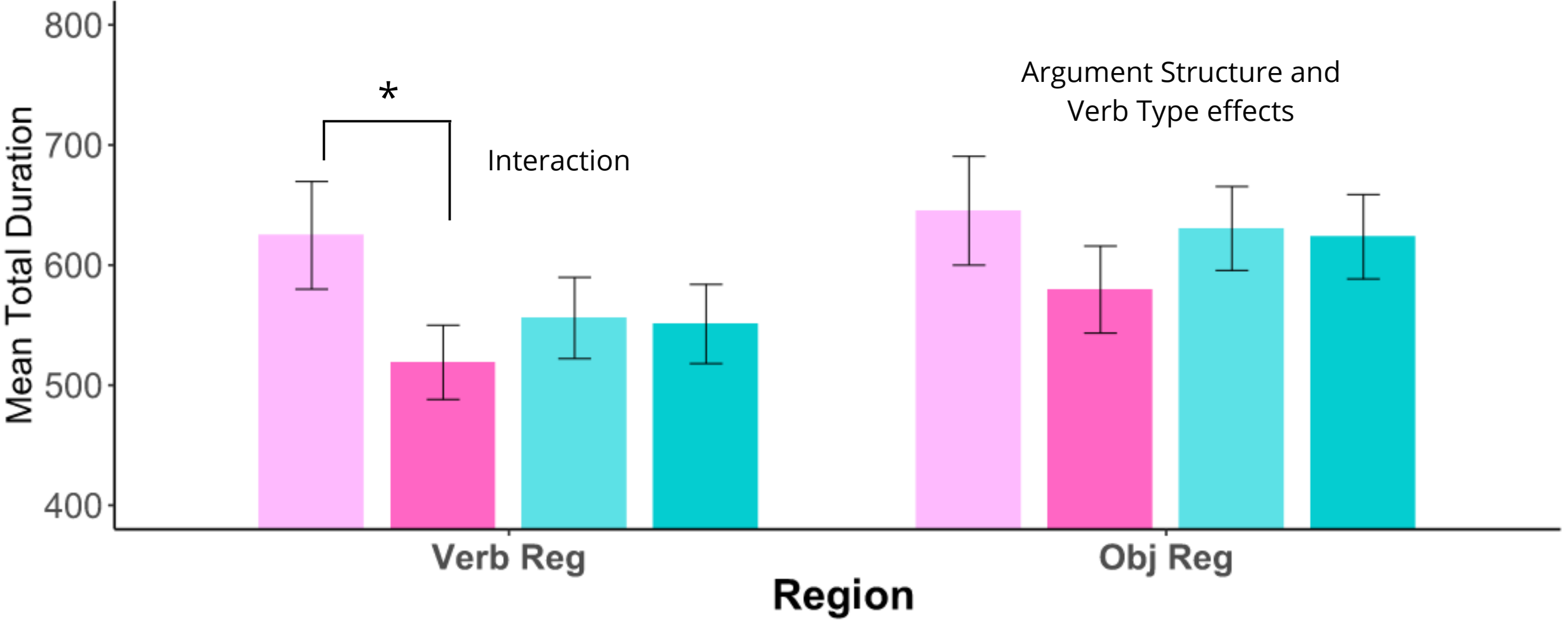
The singer /desires/contemplates/makes fall in love/abandons /the poet/during the poetry/recital.

Results

Reading Times (ms)



Total Duration (ms)



Discussion and Conclusion

Experienter role involves **increased processing load**. It is not a prototypical Agent [2].

Agent-Experienter structures have two arguments that are candidates to be Proto-Agent, increasing difficulty to process compared to prototypical Agent-Theme structures.

Experienter-Theme structures do not have significant differences compared to Agent-Theme.

We conclude that **Experienter role fits into Proto-Agent category**; it is candidate to be Proto-Agent. This involves processing difficulties in **Agent-Experienter** structures trying to determine which participant is the Proto-Agent.

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